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Johnny Varro

Johnny Varro was born in Brooklyn, New York and secured his jazz education at area jam sessions that often included Willie "The Lion" Smith and Joe Sullivan. He has played and recorded with a long list of jazz luminaries on both coasts and frequently performs at festivals in Europe. His arrangements are featured with his group Johnny Varro's Swing 7.

Johnny was interviewed in Clearwater Beach, Florida on March 16, 2001, by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive.

MR: We are in Clearwater Beach. My name is Monk Rowe and I'm very pleased to have pianist and arranger Johnny Varro with me this morning to talk about your career in music.

JV: My favorite subject.

MR: Yeah. And congratulations on your Swing 7 CD, which is a great production.

JV: Well thank you. I appreciate that. That really makes me feel good.

MR: Yeah. Is that something you've had in the back of your mind for a while, to do that size group?

JV: Well yeah, I've been writing, arranging for years and years, and never really took it too serious until I happened to be working at a jazz camp in Sacramento, out of Sacramento, and working with a bunch of kids trying to influence their jazz feeling and careers. And not too much was happening with them improvisation wise. So I thought well let me write a couple of things and see how that works. And as I wrote the stuff I began to realize the harmonies were interesting and it kind of put it all together for them and they really enjoyed what I did. And I thought to myself why don't I start writing some of this stuff for myself and put a little band together. And I started writing arrangement number one, I'm up to about a hundred now with the Swing 7. But these are all tunes and styles that I always loved through the years, with John Kirby and of course Duke Ellington, his music. And I've had a ball with it. It's been great. Volume three is about to come out any day now. I was hoping it would be out for the festival but it never showed up. But we'll see. It'll be out soon.

MR: Is it conceivable to keep a band together these days as a working unit?

JV: Well I don't keep a band together because it's hard to keep them. You know I keep my book together.

MR: Right, okay.

JV: Wherever I go if I'm in New York I pick up the New York players, which is usually the guys that are on the CDs. In Florida here I have a Florida band, and when I go out to L.A.

I pick up a bunch of guys from L.A. So as long as the book is together, and these guys can all play here, there, everywhere, as long as they can read and have a sense of improvisation, the band is usually good. But the New York boys are —

MR: I guess there's a reason for that. Everybody seems to end up there at least for part of their careers.

JV: Well look at the personnel, my God. You know these are the top players.

MR: How much time would you get, or did you get, in the studio, to do a production like this. I mean you've got fourteen cuts on there.

JV: Yeah. We did it, including rehearsal, two days.

MR: Oh. That's wild.

JV: Yeah. Before this last CD that we did we used to get together the day before and rehearse and then come in the studio the next day and play, and then for two days. But this time we decided to rehearse on the spot. And we found that we had the tape running even during the rehearsal as we ran at first, and these guys could read so well that it just, even the first take on rehearsal, we used several of those. And once in a while we'd say let's do another one. But I don't like to do too many.

MR: Yeah. Well I guess that's been, when you look back in the history of jazz recordings, they're usually done fairly quickly.

JV: Well I think it should be. I don't think — for example I did a thing with Ruby [Braff] about two or three years ago, and one take, right through, the whole thing. I mean no second chances. You better do it right the first time. Because Ruby doesn't like to do them more than once either. Mistakes and all, if there's a little slur here or something, go with it. And there's something to be said about that. It's spontaneous. That's what jazz is anyway.

MR: Right. Let me take you back if we can. You grew up in Brooklyn?

JV: I was born in Brooklyn.

MR: Did you grow up in New York?

JV: You mean playing wise?

MR: No just as a child.

JV: Oh yeah. I was born in Brooklyn, born in Bensonhurst and raised in — sorry — I was born in Flatbush and raised in the Bensonhurst area. Bay Ridge, Bensonhurst.

MR: Can you recall the first kinds of music that entered your—

JV: Yeah, it was my first studies. When I was ten years old we had a piano in the house, and the girl next door was taking piano lessons and Mom didn't want to be left out. She said why don't you take some piano lessons, which I didn't really want to do. But once I got into it I found it came easy. I kept skipping ahead to the next lesson. And before you

knew it the teacher was giving me extra stuff and I bypassed this girl and that guy and everything. It came pretty easy and the mechanics of it was — I found it quite interesting.

MR: Did you find a point growing up that, you started to think about this as a career?

JV: Yeah, when I started doing lousy in high school. After, maybe I was about fifteen, sixteen, I'd still been studying piano but my jazz influence came into me through my father, who loved jazz music, could have been a musician, wasn't. Had all the instincts. And he used to take me to jazz concerts. I was just talking about that to someone earlier. The first concert I attended was at Carnegie Hall. Eddie Condon had a big, massive jazz party, right on stage there. He had four pianos, four grand pianos, four basses, maybe three or four drummers, all lined up. And of course it was small groups at first and then this was the finale with all the players. But the informality of it, I just couldn't understand. He's walking around the stage while the guys were playing and he's chatting with this guy and he's pointing to this guy to take a solo, you next he's going. And then he'd get on the microphone and mumble something.

MR: Not your typical Carnegie Hall.

JV: Well Eddie was that kind of a character. And I couldn't quite figure this out. And at the end of the concert my dad asked me, "How did you enjoy it?" I said it was all right, just kind of confusing. I was maybe fourteen, fifteen. And he took me to another one later on, there was just one band playing. I forget where it was. The Ziegfield Theater I think. And there was a bunch of Condonites, you know.

MR: Condonites.

JV: And I caught it and they started playing and all of a sudden I got a chill. The sound of it, the brass, you know, it was so exciting to hear that raw sound coming through. And I said gee this is good. This is good. This I understood more than the other. Now I understand the other, more so now. But at the time it was kind of confusing. And I thought this might be something I might want to do. I was doing lousy in high school. My interest wasn't there. I mean two classes I was good at — music appreciation class and phys ed, or sports, or whatever, you know, baseball and things like that I was pretty good at. But the regular curriculum, no, it wasn't for me. And I barely graduated but my interest in music, my teacher was very instrumental in helping me. She was an ex-concert pianist, retired. And she'd give me a lesson and I'd play, I'd do the lesson, perform it for her, whatever she gave me the week before. And at the end of the lesson she'd say okay, now play something for me. And I'd play some "Sweet Lorraine," something to that effect. And she sat back and loved it. She loved that I was doing that. A lot of teachers in those days would have resented that and said how dare you. No, she was pretty cool about that.

MR: And how did you learn "Sweet Lorraine?" From sheet music?

JV: Sheet music. Originally sheet music and sheet music had the chord symbols and the melody and all that accompaniment and I played with the accompaniment and all, but I never knew what those figures were up above. Nobody ever told me. I had no theory. Never had theory in my life. And finally one day my dad came home, my dad again, he came home with a bunch of books. The Winn books W-I-N-N, *How to Play Ragtime*, *How to Play Breaks and Endings* and all that sort of different things. And in the back of the book there were chords with the notes on them. And I said aha, that's what this C seven means. And I wound up that I would write in little things in the sheet music, in pencil, and write in little fills and then I'd apply them to different chords and different situations until I had them memorized where I could just play it. And the light bulb went off. And I felt really great about it.

MR: That's cool.

JV: Yeah. It was really good. It opened up a whole world for me. And about that time I said hey, this is a way to make a living possibly. I started getting wedding jobs and wedding jobs didn't pay very much, it paid anywhere from twelve to fifteen dollars for the night. But in those days it wasn't too bad. Those days. Sounds like the Middle Ages.

MR: Right. But you were still, what, still in your teens?

JV: I was, yeah, about that time I might have been about seventeen, eighteen.

MR: So, fifteen bucks a night.

JV: Yeah. Well that was all right.

MR: Not too bad, yeah. And what would the band consist of? A quartet and so forth?

JV: Trumpet, a tenor player, usually clarinet, tenor, maybe no bass. Guitar probably, drums and piano. Small groups. And we played the typical wedding songs and the "Miami Beach Rumba."

MR: Yeah. Well those can be good proving grounds because you've got to learn to do just about everything.

JV: Well yeah. Oh listen it was good, great, you know. Some of the players were good. Some of them were pretty bad too. But you learn too. You grew that way.

MR: Right. Well your father certainly set you on a definite path then.

JV: Yeah, yeah, yeah.

MR: Nice memory.

JV: Oh he was great. He used to — we used to go to Eddie Condon's, he used to take me to Eddie Condon's when I was still young, in my teenage years. Take me to Condon's and we'd sit up in the balcony. I was looking at the Ken Burns film the other day and it showed a shot of Condon's and you could see the balcony. It was taken from the balcony from here, but we used to sit over here and I'd look down on the piano, the piano keyboard would be laid out there. And I'd watch Joe Sullivan and Gene Schroeder and all

the piano players that played, James P. Johnson and all those guys who used to play with Eddie. And I got a great education just listening to these guys play and how they played and how they approached the music. Subtly or unsubtly.

MR: They probably didn't have much music sitting in front of them, did they?

JV: Oh no, none at all. No. I couldn't understand that at first either. But then I got to realize you learn the songs. After I learned my first song I said ahhh, that's how they do it. Learn the song and then go from there.

MR: Yeah. That whole scene, that as you said Condonites, what was it that made that almost a style in itself, the way those guys played or just their personalities?

JV: Well the informality of it was very important. It was loose and relaxed. Well I'm going ahead of myself, but I'm going way ahead of myself, I don't know how far do you want me to go on this thing. But I did work at Nick's for a while, Nick's with Phil Napoleon and later on with Pee Wee Irwin. And this is in the 50s, the mid-50s. And Nick's was a very formal place. The music was very strict and they wanted you to play a certain style, two beat more or less, and don't swing too much. Yeah, yeah really. I mean the bands were very precise and good, good groups, I mean a hell of a good bunch of bands, good players too. That's when I first meet Kenny Davern, with Phil Napoleon — I'm sorry, with Pee Wee Irwin at Nick's. And later on I worked, about two years later I got a call from Eddie Condon to work his saloon, as a soloist. Actually it was a duo with Buzzy Drootin on drums and myself. And I noticed the informality of that place, it was so much looser and easier going and they weren't worried about whether you're having a drink or stuff like that. You know, so some of us abused that privilege too.

MR: Well I hear, I mean I've read of course that he was a major league drinker.

JV: His whole band was.

MR: His whole band?

JV: Yeah, a lot of them. A lot of the guys. Most of the guys were.

MR: Is there a reason that jazz is associated with that? I mean is it as simple as the fact that it's played in bars?

JV: Yeah I guess that is the main reason. I don't know, it kind of relaxed you I guess, if you have a couple of snorts you are able to go out and throw caution to the wind and say oh I'm going to hit that high C or I'm going to do that run a little faster or something to that effect. Strangely enough, a lot of musicians are insecure to begin with. I shouldn't say a lot because — speaking for myself I felt insecure at the time. I wasn't sure that I qualified to be playing with all these guys. So maybe a couple of drinks would loosen me up and I'd feel better about it myself you know. Sometimes it would hurt you too. If I did a recording when I was having too much to drink it wouldn't turn out as good as I thought it was at the time. So you had to be careful about that. Trial and error.

MR: I read somewhere that you had sat in or played for Willie "The Lion" Smith? Is that right?

JV: Willie became one of my first mentors at the Central Plaza. Now I'm going back a couple of years to when I was about nineteen or twenty. The sessions were run in lower New York, New York City on the lower East Side. It was the Stuyvesant Casino and the Central Plaza. There are two big halls. And on Friday and Saturday night each hall would have their own jam session. One was run by Bob Maltz and the other was run by Jack Crystal, who is Billy Crystal's dad. That's why Billy's got such a great influence in the music of today, I mean he just loved the times. And he'd be running around the hall there as a little kid, you know, and just absorbing all this stuff.

MR: Didn't his father sell records or something too?

JV: Oh yeah. He was the manager of the Commodore Music Shop on 42nd Street. And that's where I first met him. I was about fourteen or fifteen when I used to go in there and buy my first — not LPs, what am I saying — 78s. They cost a buck in those days. And that was pretty — a buck and three cents. And I met a lot of musicians going there and checking out their own records. Bud Freeman for one.

MR: Really.

JV; A funny guy. But I got to admire all these players and eventually in time in the future I wound up playing with most of them. And that was a big kick for me and a big thrill to admire these guys for years and then become their contemporaries.

MR: Did you have to work non-music jobs on the way up?

JV: I did one gig. I did one job that lasted about six months. I had fallen in love with a girl when I was about nineteen years old, some gal in Brooklyn, and she didn't like the idea that I was playing my weddings and doing that on weekends. And she'd be by herself. And so I decided that maybe I should get a career, you know. Dumb kid in love at nineteen. So I got a job in an office and did that for a while and found out that I was making more on the weekends playing those two wedding jobs or whatever it was, than it was with the whole week. I mean jeez, I was making like thirty dollars a week, taking a subway back and forth every day. It was ridiculous. I mean those are bad wages in those days, but I guess they were average. But it was minimum wage, that thirty bucks. But I'd wind up making thirty-five, forty on the weekends. And I said hey, what am I doing knocking myself out. And I decided that I wasn't in love. No this isn't love.

MR: I guess she didn't become your wife?

JV: No. No that's an old story. That's another story. We'll do that on another interview.

MR: Yeah. Part Two.

JV: Part Four.

MR: Oh my. Well see 19 — you said this is the early 50s?

JV: Well I'm kind of jumping around a lot. I don't mean to. But the love romance was around 1950. And then working at Nick's was '54, '55, '56. And then Condon's was '57. And I was there for about eight months playing intermission with Buzzy Drootin and the band consisted of Wild Bill, Peanuts, Cutty Cutshall, George Wettling, Gene Schroeder and Arvell Shaw maybe or Walter Page, one of the two.

MR: Really? Walter Page?

JV: On bass, yeah. I'm sorry, Leonard Gaskin. Leonard Gaskin was on bass there.

MR: Okay.

JV: And then that whole band went to England, was invited to England to do a tour. So then they got Jimmy McPartland in there, Pee Wee Russell, Vic Dickinson, Buzzy and I went on piano and drums, and that's when we had Walter Page on bass. And they were away for about two months so we had a ball playing there, and of course on Tuesday evenings it was guest night. And they'd bring people like Bobby Hackett in or Billy Butterfield or Bud Freedman. Bud was always there. He was always hanging out there, whether he was invited there or not he was always hanging out with his buddies. Jimmy and he were very close. And I got into the fold that way. And before you knew it I was invited and got calls from these guys to play. "I've got a gig in Long Island" or something here, and I started moving around and it was going well for me.

MR: What would happen on a gig like that if someone called a tune and you didn't know it?

JV: I had several experiences with that. In the beginning I felt hesitant about saying I didn't know a song I thought I can get by with it. And a lot of them you could. You could kind of fake and figure out. But once in a while you'd get one where and it would be some strange changes in it. And it would be embarrassing. I was very embarrassed about that and I decided I've got to learn these songs. So I started to increase my repertoire, to keep a little step ahead of all these guys so before they called them out I'd know them. So it's rarely that I get stuck, but still today, even today, somebody will call something, but now I don't feel funny about saying hey, wait, no.

MR: Better we do something else.

JV: Yeah let's do something else.

MR: I guess I'm curious because there wasn't jazz books like today, so did you just like keep your ears open and say oh I hear someone playing this tune and I don't know it, I'd better learn that one.

JV: Well there was a fake book that did come out around the 40s. It was the first fake book. I still have it.

MR: Really.

JV: I still have it at home, God the thing is falling apart. But it was illegal to have it. Because these people, the songwriters were getting no royalties out of this. So it was a legal thing.

I paid twenty bucks for it then. And I treasured it. And all the tunes were in it. And so I got to learn a lot of songs through this book. If I heard a song being played that I didn't know I'd go home and learn it. So I'd try to learn two or three songs a week and after a year or two I had a pretty good repertoire. I was in pretty good shape at that point.

MR: I see you served in Korea in the service.

JV: Yeah. I was there from '51 through '53. No I was in Korea for all of '52 that is. I took — I was a radio operator. And I went over there and did radio. And when I got out I sat home and it was like March of '53. And I'm sitting home and I'm not knowing what to do with myself. And the phone rings. And, "Hello?" "Hi, Johnny, this is Bobby Hackett." Very serious. Bobby Hackett, oh my God, I loved him, I mean he was somebody I admired all my life. His knowledge of music, his knowledge of chords and everything, it was very intimidating to me. However, he said, "What are you doing?" I said, "Not very much, I just got out—" He says, "I know, I've been keeping track of you, that you were in the service." He knew my dad worked in Cromwell Drug Store in the RCA Building and NBC studios were upstairs. And these guys would come down and say, "How's Johnny doing? What do you hear from him." Da-da-da and all this. Bobby says, "I know you're back." He says, "I think you should come with me, I'm going on tour." I says, "Gee Bobby, I don't know, you know I haven't played for two years, I'm out of shape." He says, "Tell you what. Meet me at Lou Terassi's." Lou Terassi's was a club on 47th Street, I think 47th or 48th off of Broadway. And I said I can be there in a hour. He says okay I'll meet you there. Bobby talked Bostonite, although he was from Providence. So I showed up and he says, "Play something." There was a piano there and everything. And I sat down and I started to play a little something. And the next thing I know there's a bass player playing with me. I look up it's Leo Guarnieri. Johnny Guarnieri's brother. And he was working there on a steady basis, and happened to be passing by. So I said thank God. I played a couple of things and I finished and I got off there and Bobby said, "I think you should come with me." I said, "Gee Bobby, you sure?" He says, "You did a couple of things wrong on this song" and blah-blah-blah, "but we can straighten that out, don't worry about it. And sure enough I went with him. We played the Grandview Inn, we played the Blue Note in Chicago, we played some great rooms. And while we're playing Bobby is teaching me songs and instructing me, don't do that, change this, do that. C seventh. Concentrate. Pay attention. But I'm learning man, I'm learning so much. And he was so patient and great. It was only a quartet, Buzzy was on drums that I'd known — no I didn't know Buzzy, that's when I first met Buzzy and played with him later at Condon's. This was '53. I'm jumping around a lot.

MR: That's all right.

JV: Maybe you can edit.

MR: Of course Bobby, he knew, as you said, he knew chords, he used to play guitar too.

JV: Oh yes, yes.

MR: So he really knew his harmony and all that.

JV: Yes he did that's very true. He's one of the few in those days that did, of the horn players. Horn players, most of them played by instinct, by ear, by hearing. But Bobby knew his changes. And like some of these other guys just played — I mean they did just as well in a lot of cases. But Bobby's harmonies were so great. He knew — he'd sometimes hit that third on the bottom and then go the rest of the chord up. He was a great teacher. A great influence.

MR: A great sound too, huh?

JV: Oh Jesus man, he was beautiful. We are doing a concert next month in Gainesville, a tribute to Bobby. So it should be fun.

MR: Wow. So you're kind of now establishing yourself as a jazz piano player. And I'm curious what influence the current pop trends at the time—

JV: At that time.

MR: At that time would have on what you guys needed to play on a job. Was there any?

JV: Pop meaning what?

MR: I guess I'm meaning things like that would be on the AM radio at the time, either the beginnings of rock & roll, I guess I'm moving later into the 50s or "How Much is that Doggie in the Window" kind of things that were hits back then. Did they have any influence?

JV: Probably not. They probably pushed me into the direction of real jazz. And get that away from me. Doggie in the Window. There was, well you know you'd turn the radio on and you'd hear Doggie in the Window and the next thing would be a Benny Goodman tune or a Tommy Dorsey big band thing or some small group. You'd hear, they mixed it up quite a bit. It wasn't so personal now.

MR: Yeah. So that was really part of the pop music, popular.

JV: Yeah.

MR: All right.

JV: Yeah, Goodman and some of those things. You'd hear a trio and you'd listen to Make Believe Ballroom and some of those shows, William B. Williams especially in New York, WNEW had a lot of that stuff going on and later on Fred Robbins took over and was playing mostly jazz.

MR: I see. So you didn't really have to search the dial to find jazz oriented music like you do now?

JV: Well you know, there wasn't anything like a real jazz show where it was all jazz. You know I don't think there was. There might have been — Fred Robbins might have been

one of the first to put a lot of jazz together, compile it in one section, in one half hour thing or an hour program.

MR: Were you a member of the musician's union at this time?

JV: Yeah I joined when I was eighteen. And it was a joke almost. I got in there and they said — they handed me a piece of music which was Schubert's "Serenade," which I'd played five years earlier. I sat down and I went [scats]. That's all right. Okay. That's enough. So I could read whatever was put there. Kind of silly

MR: You were expecting like—

JV: "Give me the money and pay your dues and you're a member." A joke.

MR: Have they ever come to bat for you over the years?

JV: No.

MR: Okay. Enough said.

JV: For what? I don't know. I wouldn't know what to complain about.

MR: Tell me about "The Jackie Gleason Show" and how that came about.

JV: Well when I was at Nick's with Phil Napoleon in '54, a lot of celebrities used to come in, people would come in and dig the music and stay until, God we went until four o'clock in the morning in those days. And we'd have an audience on for that last set, we'd have at least two dozen people there sitting around the bar waiting. I guess they had to go to work in the morning but the music was entrancing to them. And this one night Jackie came in with an entourage and sat and listened to the and loved the band. Phil Napoleon — I might have misled you in some way, I said it was kind of tight and two beat and all that, but it was really a very good band, very clean and some great players. Jackie loved that. He loved the music. So he was starting "The Honeymooners." And he hired us as a unit to play for the warm-ups. Like we'd play a half hour before the show was to start as the people would come in and they'd sit in the audience and we'd play about a half hour. And then we'd take a break and the announcer would come out and explain what's going to go on with the show and then we'd come up and we'd do another tune. And then the show was ready to start. And we would play between scene changes and play them off on the end. And they had the front row set for us so that when we finished playing we'd just sit down right there. And here we watched all those original Honeymooners being done live. I mean I see them and I hear us laughing. Phil Napoleon had a very infectious laugh. And every once in a while I'll hear him and I'll say oh God, there's Phil. Maybe to score brownie points with Jackie, I don't know, laughing harder than usual. I shouldn't say that. But we did that for two years. So we caught all those Honeymooner things. I mean it was just classic stuff. And they're so great. And that lasted for two years. And then several years later, let's see that was '55. Then in '65 I got a call — I'm jumping again — but Jackie had the show in Miami, the "American Scene Magazine" I think it was called, an

hour variety show. And I got a call from Phil Napoleon again and he says, "What are you doing at this point?" I said, "Nothing." He says, "Come on down, I've got the Gleason show, I've got the race track on Saturdays, and we've got a steady gig in the Roney Plaza Hotel six nights a week." I said, "Send me a ticket." And it was snowing, it was January, it was snowing in New York and horrible and freezing and I had no work. He says, "The temperature here is 78 degrees." "Send me a ticket. I'll be right down." And I worked for the Gleason show for another two years on that. I had never worked directly for Gleason, but worked for Phil, Phil Napoleon. And we played all his parties, we played the train ride down, he used to have a train. It would start out with a party at Toots Shor's in New York and we'd be transported to a train, Gleason had his own train, and we'd go down to Miami by train and play on the train and party it up. It was just one big party with all the June Taylor dancers and Art Carney and Frank Fontaine and all that whole bunch, Sheila McRae.

MR: Oh, Frank Fontaine, I haven't heard that name in a while. He was a great drunk, wasn't he?

JV: Oh Jesus, yes.

MR: In watching those Honeymooner shows, did they ever have moments where things went wrong, or were you aware of them?

JV: They rarely did two takes on something, unless something went drastically wrong then they might stop it and we'd get up and play, and they'd make some changes or reset themselves. But hardly ever. I remember one time in Miami after the original Honeymooners they did a thing and Jackie was supposed to crash into a brick wall. And he did, something happened and he went crashing into this wall and he broke either his wrist or his ankle I forget what it was. But he broke something, but he went on and carried out and finished the whole night and he wasn't going to take a break for that. Yeah he was quite a guy.

MR: Your day-to-day business of making career in music has mostly been of your own initiative? Did you ever have an agent or a manager doing any of that stuff for you?

JV: No, never. Never. I don't know why, no one ever approached me and I've never approached anyone. It's been okay for me. I telephone. Call me by rep I suppose. It's been good that way I really feel fortunate in that respect.

MR: And you've never had to revert to an office type job?

JV: Not after that first one. No I never have. Never did anything else man. I was very lucky there.

MR: What prompted you to move to the West Coast?

JV; Well after I moved down to Miami in '65 I was there for — I got married and had a couple of kids in the 70s. My daughter was born in '72 and a son in '77. And in '79 the

bottom fell out of the business. I did have a hotel job. That's another thing. I did work in a hotel in Miami. That was pretty steady and that was very good for me. Financially it set me up pretty good. But the bottom fell out of the business in Miami too. Condominiums became the big word, the big thing, people became residents instead of tourists. And it just shot the music business. The hotel business was shot and so hence the music business too. So it was time to leave. There's always a time when you have to make a move. And I did that and decided to either come back to New York — I tried a year in New York. It was okay in '78. It wasn't bad. But I'd never been to the West Coast and a couple of friends of mine had moved out there. So in '79 we moved to the West Coast, Los Angeles. And I was there until '93, another fourteen years. Fourteen years in Miami and fourteen years in Los Angeles. And that was great for me. It really was some good fans and good jazz lovers there. And I got to play with a whole bunch of musicians I had never played with before, the West Coast guys. Nick Fatool, Eddie Miller, Dick Cathcart, Bob Havens, Abe Lincoln — well just to name a few. I can name several more but I can't think of them off hand. But it was good and I developed a following. I even had a steady gig there. I have a five year stint at a club called Gatsby's, which was owned by the same guy who had the Gatsby's in New York, Bill Rosen. His wife happened to be Helen Grayco, who was the vocalist and singer with Spike Jones for years. And she and her husband ran this place called Gatsby's. And I managed to get a steady job there for five years, just solo piano. It was great. All the celebrities would come in and people would come in and — I'm a movie nut so I got to know all these people and I got to know all the character actors by name and I'm always shocked that someone wouldn't know who they were. I mean some of the small guys around. "Oh yeah, Charlie Laine, yeah I know Charlie." Things like that. And I'd recall their commercials or certain lines that they did in the movies.

MR: They like that kind of stuff.

JV: Oh they eat it up. And a lot of different experiences happened there which I could recall.

MR: Any studio work?

JV: Yeah I do occasionally, I get a call to do something special. I wasn't a studio player and I didn't really like it, I didn't like the competition there, I didn't like the politics of it so I decided to steer clear of it. And there was enough jazz playing. There were a lot of good jazz clubs in those days in Los Angeles. There was Pasquale's, Dante's, Alfonso's, Carmello's, all Italian joints. They were all Italian places. And they were really good. I mean you'd play there, several of those, several times a week. The only thing with that was they never paid too much so you'd have to do special things to really make some good money. And occasionally a club date. Club dates paid well. But try to steer clear of that too, as I do here.

MR: Define, for someone who might be watching this, who doesn't know what club date means.

JV: A club date is a regular job where you play for an audience that doesn't care what you're doing. If you're playing a wedding, nobody cares who the band is. If you're playing a dance, no one really cares what the band is.

MR: It's funny when you think about you get paid more on the jobs where people don't care what you're doing.

JV: Exactly. Isn't it ironic?

MR: Wow. What do you think of the state of jazz these days?

JV: Well it's strange because there's such separation between the styles. When I grew up in New York there was one style of playing, but the styles were kind of bebop and swing were combining in a way and there was such mixture of players and musicians that you would be able to function well enough with the next player even though he might have been a different style. It was still close enough, and as long as it swung. That was the important thing, if it swung, to me anyway. And it don't mean a thing— And today there's so many different styles of jazz, there's no real — I hear some of the fusion players and some of the avante garde players putting this music down that we're playing here, which comes from say the Swing Era, mainstream jazz. And as if to say there's nothing new being created with mainstream jazz. We've got to do something more creative. It's got to be original. It's got to be different. Always strive for different. Well we strive for different things, different phrasing, different solos, I try never to play the same solo on a particular song. And so I hear all these other players do that. And there are some great players at this festival and at the festivals that we usually wind up with. I challenge anybody to be as good as some of these players down here. I don't care what style it is. To me jazz should be a happy, peaceful thing. It should not be an angry jazz form. And I hear a lot of anger coming out in some of this other music. I can try to appreciate it and I do appreciate some of it. I try to find some qualities and some good things in it, but I always have to come back to this style to really find satisfaction say. This is where it's at really. This is my kind of music. I love it, I enjoy it, and I'm constantly trying to be creative.

MR: When I look at the players that excel at this kind of music, I don't know what we want to call it, but I guess classic or mainstream.

JV: Mainstream, swing.

MR: I don't see many young black players coming up. Now there seems to be a lot of younger white guys who are a generation below you I guess that are embracing the style. And I'm wondering why.

JV: It's very sad. I'm very sorry to hear that because as I was saying, years ago when I played this music I was a young kid. And a lot of young kids, there was Johnny Windhurst, Bob Wilber, Kenny Davern, a young crop of musicians playing and we'd be playing with mixed bands like crazy. I mean I'd be — I was on a band once where I was the only white kid in the band. There was Jonah Jones on trumpet, Coleman Hawkins on tenor, Benny Green on trombone, Jo Jones on drums, various bass players, Gene Ramey maybe on bass and myself, the young white hope. And it was a great education. And then most of the bands were always mixed. Condon always had a mixed band, and it was delightful. It was a lot of fun to play and you got to learn with each other and drink from the same jugs and smoke the same cigarettes and do all that stuff. I mean it was a camaraderie there. I think it has something to do with the style, the times. This music relates to a time when things were rough for the black person, not necessarily the black musician, but the black person in the Civil Rights, this would be pre-Civil Rights I guess. And I think they resent the style of the music and they just don't want to have any part of it. It kind of reminds them — this is just my own sermon.

MR: I think it's a good opinion.

JV: I'm surmising this myself on my own, I don't know whether I'm right or wrong. I think it is. I've thought about it and I think it's sad. Because like you say I just don't see too many black players playing this style of music. I can't think of any. I mean I see some of the old timers that are still around like Joe Wilder and Jackie Williams, of course Milt Hinton just passed away but he was part of it. I played with him back in the 50s. But I wish there were more. John Lamb I played with here with Buster Cooper the other day. And it was great. Great to see a mixed band there. I was delighted.

MR: Well I think it was well said, your thoughts anyway. Everyone has particular memories of Milt Hinton. Do you have any specific things?

JV: Well I first played with him and back then we did some recording for Grand Award, the Command label with Pee Wee Irwin. And then I didn't see him for a while and then I started growing with him in the circuit. I'll never forget one time we were playing a particular set and sometimes there's a little too much chatter on the bandstand. And I was playing and all of a sudden I hear, "Shh." I look up, I was playing a solo at this time and there were two guys chatting over there. And they looked up and I looked up too, I'm saying what the hell is going on? And he says, "The man's playing, be quiet." And you heard silence from that point on. So that's one of the great memories I have from Milt. I appreciated that so much.

MR: Yeah. He was, the little bit I got to know him I was amazed by just what you pegged there, that he was the greatest man, he was always happy, he was always — but there was a point where he is business. You know, this is a business.

JV: Um hum. Absolutely. Yeah.

MR: And give it the respect it's due.

JV: Yeah. Have fun but this is a business. Yeah he was one of a kind, man. I really loved him.

MR: Let me put on just a piece of this, I think I got —

[audio interlude]

MR: Nice.

JV: Wow. Who is that?

MR: This is all —

JV: This is John Curtin style.

MR: And this is all written out, correct?

JV: The solos aren't. That's Harry Allen and Dan Barrett. Slips through three chords.

MR: Nice.

JV: The background is written. Now this is open.

MR: Love that.

JV: This is written. That's all written.

MR: Beautiful stuff. Do you sit at a piano when you write?

JV: I might try some harmonies. You know if you write for four horns you might want to get the best harmony and open it up a little bit. I'll do that and some passing tones, to make sure that it jives. A lot of it I do from my head originally and then I'll try it at the piano and make some changes as I go along. But the idea comes from up here.

MR: Do you write all your own parts out and all that?

JV: I write, yeah, yeah. I'm a stickler for neatness. And I've been handed so much music that has been scribbled. And they say, "Here, play this" and you've got to — if you can't interpret the music you're not going to be able to play it. So I make sure that I write it clear enough that it's legible and understandable. And then if it's not played correctly it's their fault.

MR: You don't want to give them any excuses.

JV: No. In fact, later on tomorrow I think we have a set with the Swing 7 at five o'clock.

MR: Oh great. I'm glad you told me that.

JV: Yeah. And I've got a lot of new stuff there that's on the new CD.

MR: Cool.

JV: And we're not going to rehearse, I'm just going to throw it at them. In fact I finished a chart yesterday afternoon was it? No yesterday morning before I came here. I finished it out, I copied it and we're going to play it. It's never been played before. An Ellington tune.

MR: A premier performance.

JV: Yeah. Duke Ellington, "Stompy Jones." A great old piece.

MR: All right. Well it's been a really fun conversation. I see your daughter sings is that right?

JV: Well she used to. She doesn't anymore. She's out of the business now. But she had a little shot at it and enjoyed it while it lasted. It got a little tough. There's not that much work around.

MR: Yeah, I was just going to say, like would you recommend a career in jazz to a young person these days?

JV: Why not? I mean if they have the gumption to get into it and stick with it and work it out, and the talent of course, sure why not. But Heidi wasn't really that hot in it. I don't know what it was with her.

MR: You have to be kind of driven I think.

JV: Yeah. It's a rough business, it really is tough. And there's no point in getting into it if she wasn't going to give it her whole heart and soul and I don't think she was ready for that. And she's got other things going that she's doing very well at, so I'm happy. As long as she's happy, that's the important thing, the main thing.

MR: I'm sending greetings from Cynthia Willcox. Spiegel's daughter?

JV: Oh goodness.

MR: You probably wonder — you played with him a number of times I guess?

JV: Oh he used to come into Nick's back in the 50s, the early 50s. Spiegel used to come in and sit in and Cindy would be with him. In fact there was a little thing going there with Spiegel and Phil Napoleon trying to match me and Cindy, and Cynthia together.

MR: Oh really?

JV: Yeah at one time.

MR: No kidding.

JV: We are close to the same age, I think she's a little younger.

MR: All right.

JV: But it never materialized. She's was living in Upstate New York and she's adorable though. I like her very much. She's a good gal.

MR: Okay. Well thanks for your time today.

JV: Oh man it was great, Monk, you made it very easy.

MR: Good. Good. And I'll be waiting to hear that chart this afternoon to see how it goes.

JV: No it's not today, tomorrow afternoon.

MR: All right.

JV: Swing 7, we've got about forty minutes to play and there's a lot of stuff on there and the new chart for "Stompy Jones." And you take care, man.

MR: Thank you very much.

JV: Thanks a lot. I appreciate it very much.

MR: All right.